

stand as reminders that rebirth is possible, if only the old ways will be set aside in favor of the death-rebirth cycle that has served the commoners for the long years of the Interregnum.

## Preventing Aging

Since the fear of death looms large for so many of the formerly-immortal fae, quite a few take steps to try and prolong their lifespans. Many legends and epic stories came from the search for extended life, with outcomes ranging from sad hilarity to outright horror. The only tried-and-true method to prolong the life of a changeling is to spend time in a freehold. Changelings who have regular access to a freehold live longer than a mortal ought, and maintain their hold on youth and vitality for longer as well. Staying too long in a freehold, however, has its downsides. Changelings that spend too much time that close to the Dreaming will begin to lose connection to the mortal world outside and become overwhelmed by their fae natures. The changeling drifts further into her fae self until she enters *Bedlam*, a madness driven by a lack of grounding in the mortal world. The oldest changelings walk a dangerous line, trying to balance how much Banality they accrue simply by going out into the mortal world with how long they can remain in a freehold without slipping into *Bedlam*. Every changeling knows that sooner or later they can misstep and, should that happen, they face either Undoing or the slippery slope of Glamour-fueled madness.

This practice of spending more time in freeholds than out is common to the nobility. In recent years since the Resurgence and well into the Evanescence, Arcadian sidhe who have lived in the mortal world for many years have become known for spending perhaps too much time in their freeholds. As a result, they have been accused by commoners of drifting out of touch with the ongoing problems of the outside world to extend their own lifetimes. A dangerous example is High King David himself, who has spent more time in freeholds than out among his people in recent years. Commoners and progressive nobles alike have petitioned the King to step beyond the borders of his

freehold to see the troubles outside, only to have their pleas fall on deaf ears. The court remains within their freeholds, some say afraid of being Undone by the cold hand of time as it marches on outside the walls.

Legends speak about treasures that can extend youth or grant immortality once more, like the fabled Fountain of Youth, but so far none have been recovered. That doesn't stop many intrepid young changelings from questing to solve the puzzle of fae immortality. In the meantime, the cycle of death and rebirth marches on.

## Mortal Seeming & Fae Mien

Changelings face the rigors of age both in their mortal bodies and in changes that happen to their fae selves. This twofold process can be disconcerting for a changeling, whose *mortal seeming* might not match the age and capability of her fae self, and vice versa.

A changeling's mortal seeming is the body that hides her fae self from mundane perception. The fae is either born into this mortal body and emerges during Chrysalis as a changeling, or (for sidhe) takes over the body upon exiting Arcadia. Though the mortal shell may hide the fae self underneath, that mortal body always bears the hallmarks of the fae hiding inside. A cat pooka's mortal seeming may seem lithe, graceful and a little ferocious while an Autumn sidhe's mortal form might bear some of the striking beauty and poise of her fae counterpart.

Still, mortal forms do age and though the changeling inside might hold onto their youth and power, unless the process is held back by time in a freehold, the mortal body will eventually die. Those that do stay within freeholds to hold back the march of time can end up spending more time as a child, or a teenager, than they intended. The effects of this extended time in a freehold will eventually become obvious to mortals as a child doesn't grow older, or coworkers spot an adult that seems to never look a day over twenty. Often that can mean changelings need to abandon their mortal lives, or in the case of children their mortal families, when people begin to notice something is wrong. During fosterage, understanding older fae can take in these young changelings to prevent the attention of mortal authorities. *Bedlam* might be a terror for all Kithain, but so is exposure to Child Protective Services or well-meaning but stifling stints in mental health facilities.

Hidden beneath the changeling's mortal shell is her true self, her faerie soul or *fae mien*. Anyone who can see through the mortal disguise sees the immortal child of the Dreaming, the fae soul that has lasted through the centuries. Changelings and other denizens of the Dreaming can always recognize one another for what they are.

Only within a faerie trod, freehold, or any Glamour-infused place can a changeling's fae mien surge to the forefront and be freely seen. Still, a changeling's fae mien is always present just under the surface, ready to be spotted by any other changeling or Dreaming denizen unless actively hidden. The fae mien can be pushed aside by renouncing one's fae self, but doing that invites the coldest touch of Banality.

## The Legend of Siocháin

Legend speaks of faerie nobles that have achieved the impossible and found the delicate balance between their mortal selves and the fae souls within. The Sío-cháin, as they're called, are thought to have discovered the balance between Glamour and Banality and have therefore found true immortality. Though many question whether the Sío-cháin even exist, commoners wonder whether or not they're just happy stories to give desperate nobles hope at the end of their lives. How the Sío-cháin achieved their immortality is unclear, and wherever they are, they do not seem keen on sharing their secrets just yet.